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Leaving Home and Saying Goodbye

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An Essay on Obedience, Sacrifice, and our Final Hope

I attended the University of Michigan from 2018 to 2022. During those four years, I was blessed to be a part of New Life Church Ann Arbor and live at 326 E. Madison, affectionately known as APT. During my time in those respective circles, I had the pleasure of meeting and drawing close to men and women of the faith, being built up, instructed, and, at times, even lovingly rebuked; I truly consider myself to be the least of them. In addition to the blessing of these life lessons, I experienced greater joy and fellowship than I had hoped or prayed for; dozens of us cooked and ate meals together on numerous occasions, our individual apartments printed and shared Christmas cards each year, and often, I spent more waking hours in other apartments than my own. This was a community unlike any other I had experienced. Those days passed by quickly and my friends and I graduated and were thrown like darts all over the globe pursuing our careers. I wager that I will never share an apartment or house with any of them again and will likely never live in the same city with more than a few of them. This realization set in when I moved to Tucson for work. I wrestled with this for a summer, missing that fellowship. God was gracious to help me see the other side of this story and has “turned for me my mourning into dancing”, because of this I must praise and thank Him by sharing this brief testimony (Psalm 30:11-12). I write this to brothers and sisters in the faith, describing the unique trials and sacrifices we believers share, but also the unique hope that we hold in Christ.

God may call you to leave your home, the town you grew up in, or a place you thoroughly enjoy; leaving faithfully is an act of obedience to the Lord, and this obedience often precedes sacrifice.

“For we are his workmanship, created in Christ Jesus for good works, which God prepared beforehand, that we should walk in them.”

Ephesians 2:10

God knew the plans He had for the Israelites (Jeremiah 29:11); likewise, He knows the steps that our feet will take in our lifetime, and He has ordered those steps so that we may walk in them. These good works set aside for us to walk in will cost us. Jesus warned us that if any were to follow Him, they would have to take up their cross and follow Him. (Matthew 16:24) Part of this bearing up of your cross could include leaving your friends and family. The early church fathers were no strangers to this. Take Paul for example:

“36 And when he had said these things, he knelt down and prayed with them all. 37 And there was much weeping on the part of all; they embraced Paul and kissed him, 38 being sorrowful most of all because of the word he had spoken, that they would not see his face again. And they accompanied him to the ship.”

Acts 20:36-38

One of my closest friends, Nathan, in the wee hours of the morning during my final few weeks of college, told me the following: relationships are supposed to last forever, that is the way that God created them to be (Genesis 1-3, John 17:3). Everyone’s grief over broken or lost relationships, believers, and non-believers alike, attests to the fact that this isn’t how it was meant to be. This is one of the many effects of the fall: we must move away and ultimately; we must pass away; even the closest and best relationships will end. Jesus knew this very sorrow over the death of one of His friends, Lazarus; displayed in the verse, *Jesus wept (John 11:35)*. This pain we feel from our broken relationships with each other is just a reflection of our broken relationship with God. We may not directly acknowledge the sorrow caused by that separation, but we deal with the repercussions every day.

Our vertical relationship to God and our horizontal relationships to mankind were not originally designed as broken, nor, in God’s mercy, did He leave them in that state; our unique hope, now revealed in Christ Jesus, is reflected in the same story where Jesus wept:

“38 Then Jesus, deeply moved again, came to the tomb. It was a cave, and a stone lay against it. 39 Jesus said, Take away the stone. Martha, the sister of the dead man, said to him, Lord, by this time there will be an odor, for he has been dead four days. 40 Jesus said to her, Did I not tell you that if you believed you would see the glory of God? 41 So they took away the stone. And Jesus lifted up his eyes and said, Father, I thank you that you have heard me. 42 I knew that you always

hear me, but I said this on account of the people standing around, that they may believe that you sent me. 43 When he had said these things, he cried out with a loud voice, Lazarus, come out. 44 The man who had died came out, his hands and feet bound with linen strips, and his face wrapped with a cloth. Jesus said to them, Unbind him, and let him go.”

John 11:38-44

Jesus restored Lazarus to his siblings to demonstrate His resurrecting power; this was a temporary restoration, and at some point, later, Lazarus died and was buried again. Though he died, we are promised that sometime in the future, Jesus will once again say, “Lazarus, come out!” He will say this to all those who have passed away in Christ:

“13 But we do not want you to be uninformed, brothers, about those who are asleep, that you may not grieve as others do who have no hope. 14 For since we believe that Jesus died and rose again, even so, through Jesus, God will bring with him those who have fallen asleep. 15 For this we declare to you by a word from the Lord, that we who are alive, who are left until the coming of the Lord, will not precede those who have fallen asleep. 16 For the Lord himself will descend from heaven with a cry of command, with the voice of an archangel, and with the sound of the trumpet of God. And the dead in Christ will rise first. 17 Then we who are alive, who are left, will be caught up together with them in the clouds to meet the Lord in the air, and so we will always be with the Lord. 18 Therefore encourage one another with these words.”

1 Thessalonians 4:13-18

I must make one final point and reference a verse that may seem at first to be out of place with this topic:

“25 Now large crowds were accompanying Jesus, and turning to them he said, 26 “If anyone comes to me and does not hate his own father and mother, and wife and children, and brothers and sisters, and even his own life, he cannot be my disciple.”

Luke 14:25-26

In the face of leaving everything that you know or saying a goodbye – maybe even a final one – how is this verse an encouragement? I will again lean on others to help me with this point.

Taking the words of missionary Jim Elliot, “He is no fool who gives what he cannot keep to gain what he cannot lose.” In “giving up” our love for our family and friends and not seeing them or

our relationship with them as the ultimate thing in our life and instead turning to God and seeking His face as the foremost longing in our life, we shall not lose one drop of that love that we have for them, rather, that love that was once polluted by our fallen nature will be redeemed. C.S. Lewis put it beautifully by saying, “By loving Him more than them we shall love them more than we now do.” When we “hate” our own father and mother and brother and sister and become His disciples, we put on new clothes, ones that announce us adopted and redeemed; Our fallen nature starts to shed and a brighter, Christ-like image starts to shine through. The love that was once marred by personal agenda and fueled by longings which only God can fulfill is transformed and starts to look like the love that bore our just punishment on the cross. Our outstretched arms now start to receive our loved ones with the love of the outstretched arms of Him who died upon that cross. A new and better love for them is born.

On that final day we will be with him always. This gives us courage to walk in the good works that God has set aside for us to do, yearning for the day when striving will cease and we will again be with our brothers and sisters in Christ, together with Christ. If it be so, leave father and mother and brother and sister, for His sake and for the sake of the gospel, knowing that you will surely not lose your reward but gain eternal life. (Mark 10:29-30) Give your love solely to the Lord and let it be transformed so that you may finally love like Jesus loves. Lastly, grieve, but not as those who have no hope, knowing that the relationships you are leaving behind will one day be restored and better than they once were.

“7 On this mountain he will swallow up the shroud that is over all the peoples, the woven covering that is over all the nations; 8 he will swallow up death permanently. The Sovereign Lord will wipe away the tears from every face, and remove his people’s disgrace from all the earth. Indeed, the Lord has announced it!”

Isaiah 25:7-8

Feminism and Christianity

Sommer Motley

What has compelled me to write?

Growing up my father used to tell me, “Sommer, you can do anything you put your mind to.” Even though I am now 5’9, I had high hopes of being 6’ 7 when I was a kid and playing in the WNBA. I wanted to be a pink power ranger and save the world. I also wanted to be a mom and raise a family. When I was a child I felt like the world had no limits, that I truly could do anything that I wanted to and nothing was going to stop me.

Between then and now, I began to feel the duality and pressures of the world for women. In 5th grade math class, I felt out of place among my mostly male peers. In high school, it was no longer cool to wear dresses to class. In college, girls told me to forget about men, they weren’t worthy of my time and energy. All I needed to be happy in this world was to become successful in my career. A man only slows you down and takes away from the freedoms of life.

In church, I was fed the message that a woman’s greatest pride is her children and husband through the constant focus on family building. I don’t remember women talking about their jobs in church circles, and if they did it was mostly in reference to the obstacle it was to taking care of their children. Very few men ever served in childcare, and I knew from an early age that men were supposed to be the leaders of the household. Boys were taught to be chivalrous and let the girls go first without an explanation as to why they did it.

These oppositional messages from the world and from church left me confused. Neither feel like God’s intent for my life or sit well with my soul. I feel compelled to dive into femininity in the world and in the church as a way to help women sort through the mixed messaging and uncover what it means for them to be a Christian woman in today’s world. I also want men to get a glimpse into the world women live in and to understand the role that they may play in these gender expectations. I disclaim that I speak solely from my own experiences and observations, which are limited and not all-encompassing.

There are two secular perceptions of women that I am going to discuss: toxic feminism and “bro culture.” I define ultra-feminism as the idea that women are better off without men, and that women should solely focus on their careers and what makes them happy. I am all for women doing what makes them happy, but this point of view disregards the value of men and companionship in our lives as well as assumes our worth and happiness in worldly things. As a Christian, we were created for community and companionship. We were made to love one another and to have meaningful relationships with each other - including men. This perspective makes it seem like we can do it all alone, and if you have tried to do life all alone you know that we cannot. We need to depend on God for our provision, our peace, and our worth. Independence and confidence are beautiful traits for a woman to have if they are rooted in faithfulness and trust in the Lord. Otherwise, this independence leads us to depend only on ourselves and isolates us from God. Deciding that a career, financial goal, partying, or anything else will make a woman happy is putting your faith in temporary worldly things that will pass. We were made to depend on God and to be in a relationship with all of His people.

In Christian and non-Christian circles there are a few sayings that put men down in a way that reinforces the idea that women do not need men. Some of these include “men are trash” or “boys are clueless and stupid”. I have fallen victim to this mindset more than I would like to admit. These insults are used to help justify why men have mistreated women and why women therefore should seek to be without men. Not only are these words and thoughts not kind or true, they devalue an entire gender. The independence that ultra-feminism promotes is at the expense of other people, but also perhaps a response to the feeling of how ‘bro-culture’ makes women feel.

‘Bro-culture’, as defined by Elisa Garn in the context of the workplace “is the kind of environment where traditional gender roles are on full display, where “men are men” and women are...well, expected to put up or shut up”. The idea that “men are men” usually refers to when men make inappropriate, misogynistic comments or actions towards women. It’s a lame excuse for bad behavior. The culture of women being seen as objects for sexual pleasure or household wives in turn breeds both insecurity and toxic feminism in women. These comments and cultures

make women feel unsafe, unable to express themselves or trust men. They may keep some women from reaching for their dreams and it may push others to want to defy culture at any length.

Secular culture breeds insecurity and independence from our God. It makes it difficult to show vulnerability and femininity at the risk of losing respect and progress. Some of the consequences of these cultures and perspectives in my own life include feeling like I have to speak up twice as often to get my voice heard during a meeting or feeling like showing any emotion will be seen as a weakness. At different times in my life, I have responded to these feelings by being overly aggressive in trying to make my point. I feel as though I put on a mask to hide my insecurity and emotions, leaving me exhausted and feeling inauthentic. I also have responded with silence. I don't always stand up for what I think or let myself fade into the background out of fear that speaking up will come across as 'pushy'.

Traditional American Christianity is on the opposite spectrum of secular culture. Often the message told to young girls is that their role in their future marriage is to submit to their husband, be quiet, and dress modestly to avoid tempting men. These three things minimize a woman's sense of independence and autonomy. Women are encouraged to serve in childcare more than men are, despite the rising need for positive male role models in children's lives. Many Christian couples get married young without having first had time to live independently and build their careers. Boys and girls are placed in separate Bible studies and aren't given the chance to explore faith together until they are much older.

In church circles, I have felt that I have had to downplay my intelligence or avoid talking about my professional accomplishments. The emphasis on modesty, purity, and simplicity turned me away from wanting to be involved in church. Conversations about the future revolved around finding a nice, Christian husband and having kids. For me, these stereotypes were stifling. Even if I desired to someday get married and have children, I desired much more to discover my purpose in this world and my place in it. I wanted more desperately to understand Christianity and its pillars of faith. When I would ask questions about how women and slaves were treated in

the Bible or why women were supposed to obey their husbands, church leaders would either dismiss my question or say that it was all about historical context without giving me the context.

My earliest memory of purity culture rearing its ugly head was when I was eleven years old. Having just learned about sex a few months prior, I was not prepared for an entire youth group retreat centered on “saving yourself” for marriage. For those unfamiliar, this refers to abstaining from sex until marriage. This was demonstrated to me and my peers by passing around an unwrapped peppermint patty. After the last person had touched it, the pastor asked, “Does anyone want to eat this?” The message was that we would be dirty and ‘unwrapped’ for our spouses if we had sex before marriage. We were the gatekeepers to our own bodies until it was meant to be given to someone else. It was our responsibility to keep ourselves pure for someone else’s enjoyment and judgment. As girls went up to the stage to confess their sins, others were pressured into professing a vow to protect their virginity. I am not quite sure if the boys were given the same demonstration as we were, but I don’t remember them coming back from Chapel in tears as many of the young girls did.

A church, designed by God to be a place of sanctuary and community, can be a place of frustration and captivity for women. It can limit their ability to authentically connect with each other and with God because it forces them into a narrow box. Every person, every woman, is made uniquely in God’s image. He didn’t make us with the intention of putting us in boxes. He made us to live for His glory and show His love to those around us. A church, and its members, should reflect this mission.

Traditional American Christianity grants women the right to hold specific roles and purposes while binding them to toxic gender roles and expectations. As I have wrestled through my own theology and Christianity, I have found the answers to my questions, but without the help of the church. I have also contemplated the selfishness that the world promotes in women, and how it doesn’t serve God’s purpose for my life. I feel the tension of what the traditional church expects of me, God’s calling for my life, and the world’s attempt to derail both God and the church.

I was most confronted with this tension when starting a new romantic relationship. Trying to determine how I was going to interact with my partner was difficult and how I was going to portray our relationship to others was even more challenging. Was it okay for me to be focused on my career while pursuing this relationship? Was it okay for us to split the bill at the end of the date or for me to cook him dinner? What would other people think if I was too ‘subservient’ or too independent? I came to a point where I decided that all that really mattered was how my partner and I felt in our relationship. It was important to me that I felt that I could be myself and that we could express how we cared for each other in ways that represented us. It was also important to me that I continued to pursue my career and where I was feeling called to spend my time.

I also learned that the way that some churches treat and portray women is not the same in all churches. In fact, healthy churches are able to see God’s intention for women and treat them as equals. In the book “The Secular Creed,” Rebecca McLaughlin discusses how Jesus and the Bible actually promote gender equality. I have met a Christian woman who is a teaching pastor at my parents’ church, a lawyer on the weekdays, and a preacher on Sunday mornings. I have read Christian books by women and how the Bible has allowed them to live authentically and unashamedly with the freedom that only Jesus can bring. I also know a woman, in the same career space as me, who is an amazing mother and wife. She is a fierce servant in my church and is someone that I aspire to be like.

There are Godly women who are able to live in these polarizing tensions because the true message of the Bible is not one of only independence or submission. The Bible is a story of how Jesus came to save all people from their sins by dying for our salvation. He elevated women by loving them, regardless of their marital or working status. Mary gave birth to Jesus as a virgin. The Bible has changed my life and helped me to feel comforted and empowered to be myself regardless of what different social messages say to me.

You as an individual must wrestle with what the Bible actually says, God’s heart, and the world to discern what all of these messages mean. We have to sit in the uncomfortable parts of the Bible and determine how they apply to today. We also need to stand against patriarchy in the

church and the ickiness of feeling like second-class citizens in our places of worship. Ladies, we need to be confident in ourselves and who God made us to be without leaning on only our own desires and abilities. Rejoice in all of the ways that God has blessed you with your talents and gifts. Stand firm in knowing that God made you good in His image. All else falls away in the truth of our God.

Beyond the 5 Stages of Grief: The Bible's Case for Loss

Sommer Motley

When a loved one dies, the people they leave behind are stricken with the complications of grief. Not only are the emotions of what people feel layered, but the world's repercussions for death delays the grieving process. Wills, estates, funeral costs, medical bills, inheritance taxes, and obituary writings are just some of the matters that need to be handled by the family of the deceased soon after their passing. When the world demands that we handle the monetary and physical remnants of a person's life before navigating the emotional remnants, we find these expectations are prioritized before grief. Furthermore, grief isn't just the loss of a loved one but the feeling of sadness and disappointment from loss. Today, the grief of losing a job or an opportunity, grief of a divorce, breakup, or grief of losing a home can create the emotions of grief. Like most emotions of sadness, our world seems to promote distraction and compensation as coping mechanisms. Social media and commercialism create false pictures of happiness tied to working and materialism. They provide escapes from emotions of loss that when improperly processed, can lead to depression and unproductivity. The Bible provides insight into different forms of grief and how humans process and react to loss. Through biblical teachings, we can understand how people navigate the grieving process and the greater purpose it has in our lives.

In the New Testament, Jesus is on Earth as the Son of God. He performed many miracles including raising people from the dead. One of these people was named Lazarus. His sisters, Mary and Martha, "sen[t] word to Jesus, 'Lord, the one you love is sick'" (John 11:3, NIV). It says that Jesus "loved Martha and her sister and Lazarus" (John 11:5, NIV). This establishes that not only did Jesus love Lazarus who was sick, but also his loved ones. The women had sent the messenger to summon Jesus to heal their brother. In verse 14 it is revealed that Lazarus has died and Jesus sets out to see the body and the sisters. In Martha's grief, she tells Jesus that if he "had been there [her] brother would not have died" (John 11:21). Mary repeats these words in verse 32. Jesus goes to see the body and He "wept" (John 11:35). The scene is set when both Mary and Martha are stricken with grief after the death of their brother, and place at least some blame on Jesus for not healing him. We know that Jesus cared not only for the sisters but also for their brother, and when He sees the body He is overcome with emotion and weeps. Mary and Martha

have placed blame for the loss they have experienced, a common reaction to grief. They are trying to find a reason for their feelings at that moment to justify their sadness. Even more meaningful in this text is how Jesus, God on earth, responds to the death of Lazarus moments before He resurrects him. Jesus knows that Lazarus will live, but still grieves with Mary and Martha. Through this, we can conclude that grief is a holy emotion and not one that is inherently selfish. Just as Jesus permits himself to grieve, and to allow the women to express their grief by blaming Him, we too should permit ourselves to express our emotions in moments of grief.

In the story of Ruth and Naomi, Naomi has lost her husband and two sons, leaving their widows behind. Ruth is Naomi's daughter-in-law who pledges to follow Naomi back to Bethlehem, her homeland. In Ruth 1:20-21 (NIV), Ruth proclaims "the Almighty has made my life very bitter. I went away full, but the Lord has brought me back empty. Why call me Naomi? The Lord has afflicted me; the Almighty has brought misfortune upon me." In these lines, we see that grief truly is the loss of something and it has left her feeling empty. For Ruth, it wasn't merely that she had lost her family, she had also lost the right to the life and home she had built with her loved ones. She was traveling home to meet Boaz, her husband's relative and now caretaker of Naomi due to the marriage laws at that time. A woman could not own a home without a man. When her husband died and her male heirs passed, Naomi no longer had any right to her home or livelihood. For her, the grief that she felt from the death of her family was also the loss of her way of life. She was going to start over again in a different city, without anyone whom she knew and loved. When Ruth came with her, the sign of loyalty and family and promise to experience the journey of rebuilding together was a life-changing decision for both women. From this text, we can understand that death is not just the loss of a loved one, but the loss of the life that you had with them. We also understand that God calls us to grieve together and carry the burden of loss with another person. Additionally, for Ruth, the loss of her husband and love for Naomi drove her to leave behind tradition and follow her mother-in-law to a new land. Vulnerable and without protection, she undertook a new journey in order to move through the process of grief with someone else. Grief and loss, beyond the emotions, can also drive us into a new purpose and journey.

A more complicated story of loss, is the loss of a belief and idea. The story of Jonah in the Bible is one often told to heed against selfishness, pride, and disobedience. It also is a story about grief. For God, the Ninevites were evil and sinning against Him. They were "wicked" (Jonah 1:20). Still, Jonah did not want to go and warn the people of Nineveh that God was angry with them and sought to destroy the city. After being swallowed by a whale and wandering through the desert, Jonah decides to obey God and deliver the message to the people of Nineveh.

In response, the people of Nineveh repent and God spares them. “..To Jonah this seemed very wrong, and he became angry. [He] knew that [God is] a gracious and compassionate God, slow to anger and abounding in love, a God who relents from sending calamity.” He asked the Lord to take his life, “for it is better for me to die than to live”(Jonah 4:2-3, NIV). Jonah was so angry that God would change His mind after allowing Jonah to go through so much suffering. For him, the reasoning for his suffering had to be the idea that God was using Jonah to deliver justice to the people of Nineveh for their sins. When the purpose that made him obey God is changed, Jonah is angry. He is upset at what he had suffered but also what he had lost - his original purpose for his journey in the first place. While it may be an unconventional comparison, when we decide to sacrifice for a purpose whether it be a job or degree and that purpose changes or falls through we grieve. We grieve change and the purpose for which we had put our hope in. Jonah’s feelings of anger and purposelessness is similar to that of someone who has lost a job. Grief takes place in many forms for different reasons. In response to Jonah’s anger God gives him a plant for shelter and lets it die one day later. Jonah is angry again at the lack of security and comfort in his life. Just as Jonah cares about the life of the plant God asks, “should I not have concern for the great city of Nineveh, in which there are more than a hundred and twenty thousand people who cannot tell their right hand from their left—and also many animals?”(Jonah 4:11, NIV) At times, we are angry for the changes in our life that cause us pain. We grieve the loss of our life plans and purpose. Yet, the Bible allows us to reflect on the greater picture of the role that we play in the world. Perhaps our reason for suffering and purpose is not what is best for society, and instead God calls us to trust that He is “gracious and compassionate, slow to anger and abounding in love” (Jonah 4:2, NIV). For Jonah, losing his own pride and losing his expectations of God transformed him. Through this story, the Bible hopes to teach us about the self growth that can happen as a result of grief. By losing a part of ourselves, we can not only understand the world better but also understand our place in it.

The Bible is made up stories of people and the experiences that they have. Emotions like anger, joy, love, and loss are all expressed at different points, but grief is expressed in many ways just as we feel it in our lives today. We grieve the loss of people, the life we had with those who have now passed, and our declared purpose. We weep and we yell in anger, we also comfort those around us and drive forward to new beginnings. The Bible gives a complete picture of grief and some of the purpose behind it. Grief is an expression of love and passion, two things that people hold close to their heart and tie to their identity. People change as a result of loss, finding new ways to love and new passions to explore. Grief is moving through the death of something in our life we once loved and navigating a new path to find peace and happiness. The Bible

doesn't advocate for distractions or for the delay of grief, instead it offers depictions of the beauty of moving through the emotions of loss and the opportunities that it might hold.

Faith, Politics, and Jonathan Isaac

Brady Nichols

Over the summer, I was scrolling through Twitter when I stumbled upon a tweet that piqued my interest. Posted by an account called “LegionHoops” with a picture of an NBA athlete standing for the national anthem as his teammates knelt to both sides of him, the tweet read “Jonathan Isaac is launching an “anti-woke, pro-Christian” apparel brand, per @SchmittNYC.” Isaac, a small forward for the NBA’s Orlando Magic, had previously made headlines for his refusal to wear Black Lives Matter apparel and kneel for the national anthem during the NBA’s COVID-induced “bubble” during the 2020 season. He immediately became a darling of America’s political right, and his jersey sales skyrocketed. For a player with relatively few on-the-court accomplishments, Isaac gained considerable notoriety. When he appeared on my Twitter feed promoting an “anti-woke, pro-Christian” clothing line, I identified it as an attempt to capitalize on this newfound fame. I cringed at the wording and implications of the tweet, but I was not surprised. This new move by Isaac crystallizes what I believe to be a highly problematic and counterproductive political dynamic that has pervaded Christian political involvement over the past few years.

Many terms pertaining to the Christian faith have become loaded words in American public discourse. Evangelical in particular is frequently used as a shorthand for a host of other identities, including (but not limited to) “white”, “Republican”, and “wealthy”. Additionally, “evangelical” has taken on ideological connotations, and is often implicitly associated with xenophobia, nationalism, and racism. Furthermore, the term “Christian” itself is occasionally used to imply affiliation with these ideologies and identities as well. This should be deeply concerning for Christians who know that these beliefs are completely antithetical to our faith. While some of this has to do with irresponsible media coverage and a lack of nuance in the portrayal of Christians in the public sphere, I also believe evangelical behavior has contributed to these associations, including Jonathan Isaac’s. Evangelicals have consistently allowed and in some cases advocated for links between our religious identity and extreme political stances.

Isaac’s brand and the wording of LegionHoops’ tweet is a prime example of how Christianity’s public reputation can be tarnished. In the quote, “Christian” is defined in opposition to “woke”, a nebulous political buzzword with no concrete definition. When “Christian” is juxtaposed with such a term it becomes the same type of word: a political ideology that is poorly defined and a weapon of the culture wars. Within this framework, while wokeness is associated with the left, Christianity represents the right’s response. The problem is that Christianity is not that type of thing at all. Christianity is a worldwide religion that encompasses incredible ideological, cultural, and political diversity. Christianity exists to connect people with the living God as revealed in Jesus, not to enforce a particular 21st-century American political agenda. When we as Christians define our religious identity in opposition to wokeness, we are

completely missing the point. This is not to say that Christian beliefs should not influence the political positions we hold and how we apply them. But these beliefs should never be mistaken for *mere* political statements or placeholders for supporting a particular party, and our political engagement must not give that impression.

A further problem comes from the claim itself that Christianity is inherently and totally “anti-woke”. As we’ve already seen, wokeness is a vague political category. Defining whether something is woke or not is often completely dependent on your political perspective. That being said, wokeness is always associated with the more progressive side of American politics, and as a result the Democratic party. Just as “evangelical”, “Christian”, “white”, and “Republican” are often packaged together, “woke”, “leftist”, and “Democrat” have become essentially synonymous. Though blending these terms in itself is an error, for the sake of simplicity, I’ll assume that “woke” is a catch-all term for the Democratic political agenda. As I’ve already stated, the Christian faith is not primarily a political agenda. It is a message of truth about the world, human beings, and the God who created us that transcends our current political climate. One key doctrine of the faith is original sin: the idea that all human beings are flawed and fall short of the good design God has set out for us. Politically, this implies that human institutions, like political parties, will always share the same flawed nature. As such, I contend that Christians who seek the kingdom of God cannot *wholly* endorse a political party without recognizing this fundamental brokenness. On the other hand, Christianity claims that all human beings are made to bear the image of their Creator and have innate potential for reflecting the God-ordained goodness of the universe. This means that most political parties will bear some aspects of the image of God in spite of their flaws, including the “woke” Democratic party and the “anti-woke” Republicans. While there are some aspects of “wokeness” that Christians should question, we should also praise the good Democratic impulses to care for the poor, uphold the rights of the marginalized, and provide for immigrants and refugees. These are biblical principles, and we ignore them if we view our faith as the enemy of a party or ideology.

The final issue with “pro-Christian, anti-woke” rhetoric is that it diminishes our opportunity for Christian witness in a political climate that desperately needs the love of Christ. People who carefully consider opposing points of view with honesty and humility are exceedingly rare in politics. Acknowledging the beauty and goodness in opponents’ points of view will be refreshing to a culture exhausted by hatred. Affirming opponents’ inherent value as human beings might be downright shocking. Casting ourselves as enemies of the other side prohibits us from doing those things, and leads non-Christians to expect the same thing from us that they expect from everybody else: anger. Christians can have a profound impact on politics if we employ Jesus’ character in all our interactions, but falling into polarization negates that impact.

Saying we want to reflect Jesus in politics is one thing, but understanding how to do it is quite another. Nevertheless, there are key moments from Jesus’ life that can serve as a model for our political engagement. The first comes in John 4, which recounts the story of the woman at the well. The woman was an outcast in her community because of her five failed marriages. Her

status as a Samaritan made her an enemy of the Jewish Jesus and his disciples according to the racial dynamics of the day. The disciples (John 4:27) and the woman herself (4:9) were shocked that he would even speak to the woman, much less treat her as an equal. But that is exactly what he did. He reached across the barriers of race, gender, and culture to invite the woman into a relationship with him. He heard her perspective and listened to her understanding of the theological debate surrounding temple worship that had divided Jews and Samaritans for centuries before speaking on it himself. These are principles Christians should readily apply in our political discussions. If Jesus, God incarnate, was willing to allow others to speak, then we had better do the same. We should be enthusiastic about dialoguing with people who are different from ourselves and listen eagerly to their perspectives. Isolating ourselves through our rhetoric, our attitudes, and our clothing choices deprives us of the opportunity to follow Christ's example. Through Jesus, we have the power and the responsibility to hear and value all points of view, even those that we disagree with entirely.

One of the most famous political interactions in the gospels is Jesus' debate with the Pharisees and Herodians over paying taxes to Caesar recorded in Matthew 22 and Mark 12. The two groups, seeking to trap Jesus, asked him whether it was lawful to pay taxes to Caesar. This question was at the heart of a profound difference between the Herodians and the Pharisees. The Pharisees generally advocated Jewish autonomy and opposed Roman taxes, while the Herodians were amenable to Roman rule. If Jesus replied that paying taxes was unlawful, he could have sparked a revolt by the Jewish people against their Roman overlords. If he replied that it was lawful, he would have been ignoring the injustice the Roman government was inflicting on their subjects. Jesus responded to this trap by telling the questioners to "Render to Caesar the things that are Caesar's, and to God the things that are God's," (Mark 12:17 ESV). This answer demonstrates two traits that should mark Christ-like politics. First, it searches for a "third way" and evades each of the bad answers the prevailing culture offers. This is especially important in our current polarized climate. When our culture presents us with two flawed, opposite positions, we must seek to find the truth, not race to the extremes. Often this will lead us to reject the simple binary and search for something deeper. Secondly, Jesus' response highlights the magnitude of political concerns relative to our calling as image-bearers of Christ. While politics are obviously important, they are neither the ultimate source of our fulfillment nor the ultimate hope for the world's healing. In the face of polarization, Christians must remember the relative importance of politics and strive to reveal the truth rather than defend their side.

The Jonathan Isaac problem is not a one-off. It is emblematic of the larger phenomenon of polarization and factionalism that has defined Christian politics over the past few years. In it, we see the desire to protect oneself from the opposition and use faith as a weapon in the culture war rather than engage with opposing perspectives and recognize goodness wherever we see it. This impulse has led to great harm, as many evangelicals have excused misconduct by conservative figures in an effort to protect their side from criticism. Meanwhile, conspiracy theories have arisen as convenient tools to demonize opponents and further entrench divisions. This criticism applies to all of the political spectrum, but conservative evangelicals have come

under scrutiny as much as anyone. I hope that in the coming years, the church might return to a Christ-centered vision of political engagement. Christians have an incredible opportunity to disrupt cultural trends and demonstrate the gospel's power by showing love, respect, and genuine joy toward opposing perspectives. I pray that somehow we find the common sense to take advantage of it.

Dear Younger Me

By: Sommer Motley

Prelude

At the end of every academic year, I wrote my future self an email that was scheduled to be sent on the week of my college graduation. Reading these letters last spring before I graduated with my Bachelor's degree, I was reminded of the dreams I had for myself and the hope I had for the future. I was also reminded of all of the things that I had gone through to get to where I am now. At moments, these letters were cringy or brought up memories I was happy to have forgotten. They also inspired me to reflect on what I would have wanted a younger version of myself to have known or remembered. I ask my colleagues now what they wish they would have known so that I can avoid those mistakes, or at the very least find comfort in knowing that some struggles are universal. Perhaps you will read this letter and find comfort or wisdom.

Dear Sommer,

I am inspired by your joy and your drive. Your heart for God truly is on fire and is excited about understanding God in new capacities. Your prayers to know more of God's heart were answered in ways that you weren't expecting. The questions you have about life after college still aren't quite answered, but I am learning that life's path is never truly figured out. We find ourselves walking through plots of life and eventually, we look back and find that the story of our lives was exactly the way it was meant to be.

Adulting is hard and it requires both confidence in all of the abilities that you have and dependence on God for the many things you can not control. This year alone, I have seen God provide job opportunities that you have hoped and dreamed for. Despite this, I find that I don't

celebrate my wins for very long before I move on to setting my next goal. I wish you had spent more time celebrating the small victories along the way.

While I had hoped to forget about the (MANY) boy problems of your freshman year, it makes me laugh at all of the misfortunes you had with them. Those stories are still fun to talk about and can give other people comfort when the same things happen to them. I think you would be excited to know I am in a longer-term relationship, but discontent to know that it's only possible because you have learned how to put relationships above your career and above your own selfish ambitions. Loving another person means putting your ego aside and saying "I'm sorry" when you have messed up. It also means confronting the parts of yourself that aren't so neat and revealing them to someone else. In time, you find that your flaws and mess are just a part of God's story and that sharing them for God's glory is more than okay.

Your excitement for God's church refreshes me. I've been through a lot of hurt in the church since you have written this letter. People, even God's people, aren't always nice and the way we hurt each other can leave big scars. But as you remind me, building and being a part of God's church is important and an honor. I have found ways to help build God's kingdoms that you didn't know about. Fighting for equality and inclusivity, building a new church, and building community outside church have been fruitful ways to see God move in the world around you.

In a similar vein, God's faithfulness isn't always fast. Grief, betrayal, and loneliness are emotions that long for redemption. They speak to our need for God's grace and comfort. You learn that God's timing is perfect and that His love is sufficient in the ways that you need it to be and not always in the ways you want it to. Sometimes it just takes time to move through the valleys of life and you need to trust that God is taking you through to the other side even when it feels like you have taken three steps backward. I wish you would have let more people into the valley with you.

You spent a lot of time wondering about what you should be doing. Should you be applying to more internships? Should you be working more hours during the week or focusing more on your studies? Should you try harder to fit in with "the right kind of people" or try new things to see what you like? Should you be thinking more about what comes after college or

focus on the here and now? The answer is always that you aren't late or early - you are on time. God has placed you right where you are with careful thought and consideration. Everything in your life has built up to the moment you are currently living. It's easy to get wrapped up in comparison and the what-ifs, but your joy is found in living in the day that God has made for you now. There will be plenty of time later on to celebrate or worry tomorrow. There also isn't a perfect or right path, only the one that God has beautifully made for you and your story.

Let your light shine the way God has made you. Trust in the Lord with all your heart, soul, and mind. Spend intentional time getting to know God through His word and listen to His Spirit leading you. The rest will come naturally.